

The Blackout Plan

The first ten minutes, the small kit, and the calm that comes from a house that is already ready.

You watched the 60 seconds. Here is the whole thing. Fear in a blackout is just the absence of a plan. A few minutes of preparation and one written routine turn a power cut from an emergency into a minor inconvenience. Here is the whole plan.

THE FIRST TEN MINUTES

- **Find out how big it is** — look down the street. A dark neighborhood means a grid outage; if only your house is dark, check your main breaker first.
 - **Keep the fridge and freezer shut** — a closed refrigerator holds food safe for about four hours, a full freezer for about 48. Every time you open the door, that clock speeds up.
 - **Unplug sensitive electronics** — TVs, computers, anything with a chip. When power returns it can surge and ruin them. Leave one lamp switched on so you know the instant it is back.
 - **Get light up fast** — a flashlight or headlamp for every person, kept where you can find it in the dark. Avoid candles where you can; open flame in a dark house is how an outage becomes a fire.
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THE SMALL KIT (KEPT IN ONE BOX)

- **Light and power** — a flashlight per person, spare batteries, and a charged power bank for phones.
 - **Water and food** — at least one gallon of water per person per day, and a few days of food that needs no cooking.
 - **A way to hear** — a battery or hand-crank radio for official updates once the phone dies.
 - **Warmth** — blankets and a plan to layer up in one warm room. Never the gas oven (see below).
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THE SAFETY LINES YOU NEVER CROSS

- **Generators outdoors only** — at least 20 feet from windows, doors, and the garage. Carbon monoxide is invisible, odorless, and deadly.
 - **Never heat the house with a gas stove or oven** — the same silent risk, and a fire hazard besides.
 - **Install carbon monoxide detectors with battery backup on every level** — the one alarm that still works when the power does not.
 - **The 40-degree rule** — if the fridge climbs to 40°F or higher, throw perishable food out. When in doubt, throw it out.
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KEEP THIS IN MIND

Write this on one card and tape it inside a kitchen cupboard, with the flashlight box beside it. When the lights go out you do not think — you read and you do. That is the whole difference between a scare and a shrug.

A ready house is a quiet house. Your family does not need to be fearless — they just need to know you already thought it through. — The Sage

SOURCES Ready.gov, Power Outages · American Red Cross · FEMA · USDA Food Safety, Food and Water Safety During Power Outages